Matt Sumner

Director of Engineering

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SUMMARY

Engineering leader with 15 years in software, 11 of them writing production code day to day. For nearly four of those years I led teams while still coding, first as Development Director of thoughtbot's Boston studio and then as an Engineering Lead at HubSpot. I still ship the occasional change myself. I build diverse, highly engaged teams, and they deliver. I led an org that peaked at about 50 engineers, and we took HubSpot's AI agent from an early experiment resolving about 20% of conversations to 72%, across more than 10,000 businesses. I partner closely with product and design to turn new technology into products customers trust.

Expertise: Engineering leadership · Org design and team building · Developing leaders · Performance management · Product and technical strategy · Cross-functional partnership · AI product development · Change management

EXPERIENCE

HubSpot · Cambridge, MA · Apr 2020 – Oct 2026

Director of Engineering, Customer Agent · Mar 2026 – Oct 2026
Senior Engineering Manager, Customer Agent & Communication · Jun 2022 – Mar 2026

- **Took Customer Agent from a hackathon project to HubSpot's leading AI product.** Stood up its first team in 2023 to ship an AI chatbot for INBOUND, then led the engineering org as Customer Agent went from resolving about 20% of conversations at launch to 72% with no human involved, across more than 10,000 businesses and millions of conversations a month. It drove 53% of the AI credits HubSpot customers consumed (Q1 2026).
- **Owned the definition of a billable "resolution."** As DRI for Customer Agent's move to resolution-based pricing, aligned engineering, product and finance on an auditable definition of a billable resolution, and presented it to the SOX steering committee.
- **Scaled and reshaped the org deliberately.** Grew the product group from about 30 to 50 engineers, refocused it to about 30 around Customer Agent, then rebuilt to about 40 engineers across 13 teams spanning Customer Agent, Live Chat and Voice. Led through nine engineering and technical leaders, with clear ownership and metrics for each team.
- **Built a diverse org on purpose.** Reached a ~50/50 gender split through intentional hiring, and partnered with recruiting to build diverse candidate slates before hiring decisions.
- **Grew leaders from within.** Sponsored 7 promotions in 2025 (including Staff → Staff Tech Lead and Tech Lead → Engineering Lead) and coached four leads into Engineering Manager roles in 2026. By the end, the group was largely run by leaders I had developed. It ran on its own through my 4-week sabbatical.
- **Became a magnet for talent.** Many engineers name me as the reason they joined HubSpot. Filled critical roles through internal transfers, and people who already knew HubSpot ramped up faster.
- **Held a high bar with care.** Addressed underperformance directly through PIPs and exits. Spun down a legacy product team and moved its engineers to high-growth AI work, keeping attrition low.
- **Led with radical transparency.** Wrote bi-weekly "Reflections" posts (2023–2026) and ran quarterly kickoffs and AMAs. Transparency was my top-rated value in upward feedback.
- **Set direction other products built on.** Partnered with Product and Design on strategy and wrote the Customer Agent Platform vision, which Sales Hub adopted as a roadmap dependency.
- **Stayed hands-on and helped engineers adapt to AI development tools.** Shipped production code as a manager and Director, including IC embeds using Cursor for frontend work in 2025 and Claude Code in the terminal in 2026. Ran an Engineering AMA in 2025 and led a discussion within my org in 2026 on adapting code review, focusing on tools reviewers use to understand changes beyond reading each line.
- **Turned a broad quality mandate into measurable goals.** Led the org's work in a HubSpot-wide product-quality initiative; Customer Agent email churn fell from 41% to 22%.

- **Bet early on AI.** Ran product-group hackathons that led to a series of AI-assist features. Delivered 7 launches for HubSpot's 2024 Spring Spotlight, including the AI chatbot, WhatsApp in Help Desk, a Live Chat mobile SDK (built with an external partner) and Reply Recommendations.

Engineering Lead, Conversations (Live Chat & Self Service) · Apr 2020 – Jun 2022

- **Player-coach: wrote and shipped production code as a core part of the role** while leading up to four teams and acting as Tech Lead on one. Introduced TypeScript, a Rollup build and integration tests to Customer Portal.
- **Turned around a Live Chat team in "code red"** (missed deadlines, conflicting priorities, three leadership changes at once) by cutting scope into milestones that could ship in weeks. Team health and trust recovered.
- **Led the year-long, cross-group build of Customer Portal**, giving customers a branded self-service hub to track support requests and find answers. Championed integration with HubSpot's CMS and delivered general availability in the 2022 Service Hub relaunch.
- Started monthly Engineering Lead cohorts across HubSpot and drove TypeScript adoption, contributing code to it. Sponsored a Hack Diversity intern through a co-op to a full-time hire.

thoughtbot · Boston, MA · Jun 2014 – Apr 2020

Development Director, Boston Studio · Oct 2018 – Apr 2020

- Led the growth and mentoring of a ~30-person studio while staying hands-on as an engineer on client projects. Owned hiring, the studio's reputation in Boston, and winning new client work, together with global leadership.
- Advised and built for client teams including Indigo AG, Adobe, and Berklee College of Music.

Developer (from Apprentice) · Jun 2014 – Sep 2018

- Built client products in Rails, Ember, React and Scala using test-driven development (TDD) and pair programming. Wrote 10+ posts for thoughtbot's engineering blog.

The Beech Group · Phoenix, AZ · Feb 2011 – Jun 2014

Full Stack Developer. Built and maintained the Rails application that ran a medical-transportation business.

SPEAKING

- "AI Applied to Revenue," 45-minute talk, Inbound Marketing Summit 2026, Medellín, Colombia. Afterwards I met privately with customers about deploying AI agents.
- Speaker at EPIC Week, HubSpot's annual internal conference, every year, 2020–2025. Talks included "Building Psychological Safety" (later used in HubSpot new-hire onboarding), "We Write Code for Humans," "The Power of Telling People What You Want," and "Iterative Development: Working Out What to Do Next."

WHAT MY TEAMS SAY

> "Deeply empathetic and highly effective, and he never treated those as a tradeoff." *Lynnsey Martin, Tech Lead, HubSpot (direct report)*

> "The manager who truly launched my career." *Paul Leninger, Founder & CTO, Cradle (former direct report)*

EDUCATION

MPhys, Theoretical Physics, Durham University, UK

ADDITIONAL

Professional coach for technical managers and working parents (Plucky, 2021; independent, 2022–2024)